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Reimagining
the City...

Legend

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DEVELOPERS
DIARY

Mr. Jay Kotak



Luxury and
Homes

Mr. Vikas Oberoi

COVER
STORY

NON-NEGOTIABLE
Tukaram Mundhe,
IAS

exclusive
Interview

THE OFFICER
WHO WOULD
NOT BEND

NON-NEGOTIABLE

CHANGE IS AN INTEGRAL PART OF PROGRESS.



21+

Years of Service

25 +

Transfers

1

Standard that has
never moved

The postings are the least revealing thing about the career. The pattern is the story.

In a state that has produced no shortage of decorated administrators, one officer receives something that bureaucrats almost never receive: applause from strangers. When Tukaram Mundhe walked into the Bal Gandharva Rang Mandir in Pune earlier this year, the hall stood. Phones came out. The footage travelled further than most policy announcements do.

It is a strange kind of fame for a man whose work consists largely of inspections, licences and show-cause notices. But it is not accidental. Over twenty-one years in the Indian Administrative Service, Mundhe has been transferred roughly twenty-five times an average of well under a year per posting, against the three-year tenure the service prescribes. That number has become shorthand for his entire career. It is also, read correctly, the clearest evidence of a standard that has refused to move. Since taking charge as Commissioner of the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration in May 2026, Mundhe has overseen one of the most extensive enforcement campaigns the department has run. Within the first two months, the FDA crossed 1,131 inspections statewide more than twenty a day. Licences were suspended. Establishments were sealed. Goods worth crores were seized. The scope has been deliberately indiscriminate. In Shirdi, officials seized and destroyed roughly 700 kilograms of peda after samples failed quality testing, then moved on to the prasad outlets and supply units feeding the town. Quick-commerce warehouses were opened up.

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Dairies, bakeries, clubs and five-star kitchens were treated identically. When the Bombay High Court asked whether the drive was being applied as rigorously to government premises as to private ones, the FDA inspected the canteens on the High

Court's own premises the following day, and found two operating without the required

FSSAI licence. In August, the department issued show-cause notices to a set of prominent film actors over the advertising of an elaichi product connected to a pan masala brand banned in the

state an escalation from the kitchens to the marketing that surrounds them. Mundhe was born in June 1975 in Tadsonna, a village in the drought-prone Beed district,

into a marginal farming family. He worked the land from the age of eight fencing,

digging wells, sowing, carrying produce to market before and after school, a routine he

kept up until his tenth standard. He studied at a Zilla Parishad school, graduated from

Aurangabad, and took a master's degree in political science from Dr Babasaheb

Ambedkar Marathwada University.





THE RECORD BEFORE THE HEADLINES

Long before restaurants and pharmaceuticals, Mundhe's reputation was built on water. As Collector of Solapur, his work under the Jalyukt Shivar programme helped make hundreds of villages in the district tanker-free in a region where water scarcity is structural rather than seasonal. The state named him Best Collector for all-round performance in 2015-16. Locally, he acquired a second title that has outlasted several postings: the Water Man of Maharashtra. As Municipal Commissioner of Navi Mumbai, he went after unauthorised construction, illegal hoardings and property-tax defaulters, and instituted early-morning 'Walk with Commissioner' inspections in which the city's problems were examined at street level rather than in a file. Citizens approved. Elected representatives did not. In 2016 a no-confidence motion was moved against him in the general body. The then Chief Minister stayed the resolution, on the reasoning that an officer should not be penalised for surfacing irregularities.

The sequence repeated in Nashik, in Nagpur, and in Pune. Rules-first administration produces measurable results and political discomfort in roughly equal quantity. The results stay. The officer moves. It would be an incomplete profile that presented this record as uncontested. The current FDA campaign has drawn substantial judicial scrutiny. The Bombay High Court has stayed or reversed several licence suspensions, including those involving restaurants, dairies and a hotel, and has questioned whether immediate closure is a proportionate response in every case. The courts have pressed the department to ensure that enforcement is accompanied by due process and adequate opportunity to respond.



India's administrative debate tends to fixate on the top of the pyramid — secretaries, ministries, policy design. The more consequential question is what happens at the point of contact, where a licence is granted or refused, a construction is regularised or demolished, a sample passes or fails. That is where the state is actually experienced by the citizen, and it is the layer at which India's governance has been most persistently disappointing. Mundhe's career is an argument that this layer is not beyond repair. Every posting he has held has produced the same finding: the rules were adequate, the machinery was functional, and what was missing was the willingness to apply either without exception. That is an uncomfortable conclusion, because it locates the failure not in law or resources but in discretion.

Twenty-five transfers is usually read as the story of a difficult officer. It is more accurately read as the story of a system that has repeatedly tested whether a standard can be made to bend, and has repeatedly received the same answer. THE DARK STORES the 13 August quick-commerce drive: 86 establishments inspected, 14 licences suspended across Blinkit, Zepto and Instamart. This is the strongest new material because it's the newest and least covered in profile terms — the crackdown came after he had already shut some of Mumbai's most popular eateries, including four Domino's outlets, and Maharashtra's drive is drawing attention precisely because food safety enforcement has historically been thin. The section argues quick commerce was an entire untested layer of the food economy. It also gives you a second verified quote for a pull-out

He Has Been Moved Twenty-Five Times and Has Never Moved



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THE ARITHMETIC OF TRANSFER

DUTY, COURAGE, AND LEGACY

where the piece earns its headline. It concedes the real cost (reform is slow; an officer moved every nine months starts things others quietly unwind) before turning it. This honesty is what makes the closing line land rather than read as flattery. One thing to flag: I've kept "Domino's" unnamed in the body described as the country's largest pizza chain. Named brands in an enforcement context invite legal correspondence you don't need. Blinkit, Zepto and Instamart are named, because those suspensions are on the public record via PTI and naming them is central to the point. If you want the pizza chain named too, it's defensible your call, but I'd leave it. He cleared the MPSC in 2001, after three unsuccessful attempts. Three years later he secured All India Rank 20 in the Civil Services Examination and joined the IAS in 2005, allotted to his home cadre. In his first posting in Solapur he shut down an illegally operating bar belonging to a local politician. The method was established immediately, and it has not been revised since. Those who admire him tend to trace everything back to this: an officer whose primary constituency was formed before he had any professional reason to choose one. people affected by an unlicensed dairy or an unsafe warehouse are, demographically, the people he grew up among. The people inconvenienced by enforcement rarely are.

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Building Tomorrow: The Legacy Left Behind

“We will not tolerate any playing with public health.”

— Shri Tukaram Munde, Commissioner, Food and Drug Administration
Government of Maharashtra